

Instructional Strategy & Approach

Why This Module Is Built the Way It's Built

The Needs & Audience Analysis defines who this learner is. The Task & Content Analysis identifies where the original module's design created barriers for that learner. This document explains the strategy behind the revised approach — not just what changed, but which instructional design principles justify each choice, so the format isn't a stylistic preference but a set of decisions traceable back to the learner in front of it.

1. Guiding Frameworks

Three frameworks shaped every structural decision in the revised module, not just the language-level fixes covered in the Content Review Case Study.

Framework	What It Says	Where It Shows Up in This Module
Adult Learning Theory (Andragogy)	Adults learn best when content connects to their own experience, they have autonomy over pace and process, and the material has clear relevance to their lives — not just abstract skill-building.	Self-paced screens with no forced timing; the closing reflection line ties narrative voice to real writing contexts (a letter home) instead of stopping at abstract craft.
Trauma-Informed Design	Prioritizes physical and emotional safety, choice, and control. Removes mechanisms that mimic institutional control (forced compliance, visible failure, punitive framing) wherever they're not essential to learning.	Skippable video, no forced-wait gates, no visible "attempts" or error tracking, non-clinical prompt language throughout.
Cognitive Load Theory	Working memory is limited. Instructional design should minimize load that doesn't serve learning (extraneous load) so capacity stays available for the actual skill being taught (germane load).	Accordion-style definitions (one concept expanded at a time, not a wall of text), embedded story excerpts kept to 150-300 words, no multi-app navigation required to complete any task.

2. Format Rationale

Why self-paced interactive screens, not live instruction or straight video

Facility scheduling, shared device access, and variable session length make synchronous instruction impractical for this population. Self-paced screens let a learner start, stop, and resume without coordinating around anyone else's schedule — which the Needs & Audience Analysis identifies as a hard constraint, not a preference.

Why accordion/expandable content instead of continuous text

Presenting all eight storytelling elements as one long scrollable block front-loads more text than a learner needs at any single moment. An accordion lets the learner choose what to expand and when, which supports both cognitive load management and the trauma-informed principle of control — the learner decides how much detail they want, rather than having it decided for them.

Why open-ended journal prompts instead of multiple-choice quizzes

The terminal objective is expressive (apply a narrative voice to original writing), not recognition-based (identify the correct definition). A multiple-choice check would test recall, not the actual skill. Open-ended prompts also avoid a scored right/wrong structure, which matters for a population where visible failure carries more weight than it does for a typical adult learner — see the Needs & Audience Analysis, Section 5.

Why video is used sparingly and always skippable

Video adds production value but also adds risk: buffering, unfamiliar pacing expectations, and — if locked — a control mechanism the learner can't opt out of. Keeping video optional and skippable preserves its instructional value (for learners who want it) without making it a gate (for learners who don't need it or can't reliably load it).

3. What This Approach Deliberately Avoids

Some common e-learning patterns were considered and rejected, not just omitted by default.

Common Approach	Why It's Avoided Here	What's Used Instead
Gamification (points, badges, leaderboards)	Can read as infantilizing for an adult audience, and any comparative element (leaderboard, ranking) directly conflicts with the trauma-informed need for privacy in failure and non-comparative pacing.	Private, ungraded self-reflection prompts with no visible completion metrics beyond the learner's own progress bar.
Timed assessments	Time pressure adds extraneous cognitive load unrelated to the actual skill, and penalizes exactly the learners (first-time device users, non-native readers) this module is designed to support.	Untimed, self-paced completion throughout.
External links for supplementary content	Assumes open internet access this platform doesn't have, and creates an unrecoverable dead end if a link fails to resolve.	All supplementary content (craft tips, story excerpts) embedded directly in the module.

4. Traceability

Every choice in this document should be traceable to either a specific finding in the Needs & Audience Analysis, a task-completion risk identified in the Task & Content Analysis, or an objective stated in the Learning Objectives document. Where a design choice doesn't map back to one of those three, it's a style preference, not a strategy — and worth flagging for review rather than assumed correct by default.